

On the Menu

Imperialism & World War I · 1898–1919 | Standards US.19, US.20, US.21, US.22, US.23, US.24, US.25, US.26, US.27

- Archive (J. Troop)
- Spark
- Navigator
- Notetaker

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

In one generation the United States went from healing its own wounds to reaching across the whole world — buying navies, taking islands, and finally sending two million young men to a war in the mud of France. When a country grows into a world power, who pays for the growth? And when it wins, what does it owe the people it now controls?

Hold this question the whole unit. You'll answer it at the end — in your own words, from the evidence.

1 Mission Vocabulary

Write what each word means as you meet it in the stories (definitions shown).

imperialism	A policy of extending a nation's power by taking colonies or controlling other lands and peoples.	anti-imperialist	Someone who opposed the U.S. ruling other peoples without their consent.
yellow journalism	Sensational, exaggerated news written to stir emotion and sell papers — and, in 1898, to push for war.	Big Stick diplomacy	Theodore Roosevelt's approach of negotiating while backing it with the threat of military force.
militarism	Building up huge armies and navies and glorifying military power — one of the MAIN causes of WWI.	propaganda	Information, often one-sided or misleading, spread to shape how people think — used heavily on the WWI home front.
self-determination	The idea that a people should get to choose their own government — central to Wilson's Fourteen Points.	League of Nations	The world peace organization Wilson proposed after WWI — which the U.S. Senate refused to join.

2 Flight Log — every stop

One entry per landing. Jot what you *notice*, then answer the crew's debrief — the point isn't a right answer, it's your read of the evidence.

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Key (one defensible read)
1	Analyze the economic, strategic, and ideological motives behind American imperialism, and the debate between imperialists and anti-imperialists. Notice: Picture a menu — but the items aren't food. They're countries. Cuba, Puerto Rico, the Philippines, Hawaii, all laid out like dishes, and a giant... Debrief: Name the three main motives for American imperialism, then explain the core argument the Anti-Imperialist League used against it. Whose reasoning do you find stronger, and why?	Motives: economic (foreign markets and raw materials), strategic (a strong navy needing overseas bases, per Mahan), and ideological (a mission to spread American civilization). The Anti-Imperialist League argued that ruling peoples without their consent betrayed the founding principle of government by consent of the governed. Strong answers take a defensible position and use evidence, ideally weighing national benefit against the consent principle.
2	Analyze the causes, course, and consequences of the Spanish-American War, and how Roosevelt's Big Stick and Taft's Dollar Diplomacy extended U.S.... Notice: A ship blows up in a harbor. Nobody knows exactly why. But two newspapers, locked in a war for readers, splash it across their front pages... Debrief: Explain how the Spanish-American War turned the U.S. into an imperial power, then compare Big Stick and Dollar Diplomacy as two ways of using that new power. Include the war's consequences for Filipinos.	The 90-day war (1898) — driven by sympathy for Cuba, business interests, yellow journalism, and the Maine explosion — left the U.S. controlling Puerto Rico, Guam, the Philippines, and Cuba. Big Stick (Roosevelt) used the threat of force and built the Panama Canal; Dollar Diplomacy (Taft) used economic investment. For Filipinos it meant the Philippine-American War (1899–1902) and continued occupation. Strong answers connect the war's outcome to the debate over how to wield new power.
3	Analyze the long-term causes of World War I (MAIN) and the reasons the United States abandoned neutrality and entered the war. Notice: Europe in 1914 was a room full of people soaked in gasoline, and everyone was holding a match and swearing they'd only light it if someone else... Debrief: Explain the MAIN causes of World War I, then explain how the U.S. moved from neutrality to war. Identify the two events that most turned American opinion.	MAIN: Militarism (arms buildups), Alliances (Triple Alliance vs. Triple Entente), Imperialism (colonial rivalry), Nationalism (national pride/tension); spark = assassination of Franz Ferdinand (1914). The U.S. stayed neutral until German unrestricted submarine warfare (the Lusitania, 1915) and the Zimmermann Telegram (1917) turned opinion; Wilson asked for war in April 1917 to make 'the world safe for democracy.' Strong answers name the Lusitania and the Zimmermann Telegram as the key turning events.
4	Analyze the American military experience in World War I — trench warfare, deadly new technologies, and Pershing's American Expeditionary Forces —... Notice: Imagine a war where you live in a muddy ditch for months, where poison gas can roll in on the wind, where a machine gun can cut down a hundred men... Debrief: Describe what made World War I combat so deadly, and explain the role of the American Expeditionary Forces. Then explain why Alvin York's story is more complicated than 'brave soldier.'	WWI combat was deadly because of trench warfare plus new technologies — machine guns, poison gas, tanks, artillery, airplanes. The AEF under Pershing brought fresh manpower in 1918 that helped the exhausted Allies win, at heavy cost. York's story is complicated because he began as a would-be conscientious objector who did not believe in killing, wrestled with his faith, and only then became a decorated hero — his courage included moral struggle. Strong answers capture that tension.
5	Analyze the World War I home front — women's expanded roles, mobilization and war bonds, and the Committee on Public Information's propaganda. Notice: Here's something they don't always tell you about war: most of the people fighting it never see the front. They're at home, and their whole world... Debrief: Describe two major ways World War I changed the American home front, then explain what the Committee on Public Information was and one reason it is controversial.	Home-front changes included women taking on new jobs (factories, offices, nursing, farms) and civilians rationing food and buying war bonds. The CPI was the government's large-scale propaganda agency (posters, films, speakers) built to rally support for the war; it is controversial because it also demonized Germans and pressured critics into silence, blurring the line between informing and manipulating the public. Strong answers name a genuine change and a genuine concern.
6	Analyze Wilson's Fourteen Points, the Treaty of Versailles, and the debate over the League of Nations — including Tennessee's internationalist voice. Notice: The war is over. Ten million soldiers are dead. And an American president stands up and says: what if we made sure this never happens again? What... Debrief: Explain Wilson's Fourteen Points and the League of Nations, then explain why the U.S. Senate rejected the Treaty of Versailles. Was the Senate's decision wise or a mistake? Defend your answer.	The Fourteen Points (1918) proposed open diplomacy, freedom of the seas, self-determination, and a League of Nations to prevent future wars. The Treaty of Versailles (1919) created the League but harshly punished Germany. The Senate, led by Henry Cabot Lodge, rejected it, fearing the League would commit the U.S. to future wars without congressional consent. Strong answers take a defensible position, weighing the value of collective security against concerns about sovereignty and war powers.

S Source Detective

Find this primary source in Unit 3 of your book, then work it like an investigator: **This 1898 political cartoon depicts Uncle Sam as a customer eyeing a menu of Spanish colonies like Cuba and the Philippines served by President McKinley, critiquing U.S. imperial ambitions during the Spanish-American War as covered in Tennessee US.26.**

1. Who made this, and when? Whose point of view does it show — and whose is missing?
2. Spark's question: *This is the 'menu' cartoon itself — Uncle Sam deciding which country to 'order,' served by President McKinley. Ask: the cartoonist drew whole...*
3. What does this source prove — and what does it *not* prove on its own?

Teacher note: US.19/20. Steelman the expansionists; give the anti-imperialists and the colonized voice equal dignity. Andrés is the moral hinge of the unit. TN anchor: Southern reunion through the 1898 war.

A The Arc of the Union — *your call*

For each milestone, decide: did it move the country **toward** its founding promise — liberty and equality *for all* — or **away**? There's no answer key. Mark your read and back it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	Historians' read (one reading, not the answer)
1898	Spanish-American War: the U.S. becomes an empire	Mixed Historians widely agree the war made the U.S. a world power, but genuinely debate whether acquiring overseas subjects was an advance for the...
1899	Philippine-American War	Setback Broadly treated as a costly war of conquest against a people seeking self-rule — a clear setback for the principle of self-determination the U.S....
1904	Panama Canal & the Roosevelt Corollary (Big Stick)	Mixed The canal was a major strategic and engineering achievement for U.S. power, but it came via a U.S.-backed revolution against Colombia and an...
1917	The United States enters World War I	Mixed Entry made the U.S. a leading world power and helped end the war, but at great human cost and with real curbs on civil liberties — historians...
1918	The Fourteen Points: a new vision of peace	Climb Widely regarded as a landmark articulation of a rules-based, cooperative international order — an advance for the ideal of peace even though it...
1919	The Senate rejects the Treaty and the League	Mixed Genuinely contested: some historians see the rejection as a tragic retreat from world leadership, others as a defensible defense of constitutional...

B Debrief & Closing Argument

Units 1 and 2 asked what the country owed the people inside it. Unit 3 asks a bigger, harder version: what does a rising world power owe the...

Closing question: This unit put a hard idea on the table: a nation can grow more powerful at the same moment it does real harm to a people. Choose one event from this unit and argue two things at once — how it strengthened the United States, AND what it cost, and to whom. Then take a stand: was the trade worth it? Cite the unit. There's no answer key — make the case honestly.

Facilitation: There is no single correct verdict — students must choose moments and defend a direction with evidence. Reward a claim that holds competing truths (opportunity *and* injustice in the same years) over a tidy one-sided answer.

Back to the Essential Question — your answer now:

Answers vary; look for direct use of unit evidence and a defensible position, not a memorized "right" answer.